

OF CYBER RISKS AND LESSONS

WITH A FOCUS ON HOW TO STAY SAFE

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To understand hackers and how to stay secure, I interviewed Anant Shrivastava, a seasoned information security professional with over 15+ years of experience across network, mobile, application, and Linux security. A strong open-source advocate, he heads projects like TamerPlatform and CodeVigilant, frequently speaking at, contributing to and reviewing for various cybersecurity conferences and communities. Edited excerpts follow:

Q What kind of hackers out there?

A Lone-wolf scenarios are more common. However we have a lot of organized groups that don't do this for fun. The business of infosec crimes has more money involved than ever. Most of these collectives can be bifurcated in two sections – organized nation statesque actors and organized private players. The nation statesque entities are funded and fueled with a focus to disrupt nations' critical infrastructure in forms of APT's (active persistent threats). Organized private players are active in two forms – ransom players, the ones who aim to hold the systems or environments on ransom and extort money via cryptocurrency. Finally, there are players like anonymous, lulz and 4chan who are here either for fun or a very specific cause.

Q The anatomy of a hack in 2025?

A This is not fun anymore, both organized cyber crime and nation state actors are in this for serious action. The focus is on maximum impact and one way for max impact is hoarding exploits and using them for such engagements. Use of zero day exploits is on the rise. If you look at KEV Intel (kevintel.com) or CISA's KEV list (tinyurl.com/cisa-kev-list), publicly disclosed bugs getting weaponized in a few hours, not even a day is needed for attacks to start.

Q What hacking techniques are rising in India?

A For India specific scenarios, while the banking sector has one of the most mature and secure practices in India around credit card usage, the major attack vectors are now UPI frauds, and scams over WhatsApp or phone calls leveraging direct fund transfers or UPI as a money transfer media.

Q Worrisome emerging threats?

A What worries me the most are two major technological advances. 1) Deepfakes: For years, we taught people to rely on audiovisual clues to tell real

from fake and now with AI generated fakes make fraud more convincing than ever. 2) AI / LLM technology reduces the barrier to entry for creating seemingly working software, but most LLM technologies are not trained to be secure in terms of the code they produce.

Q Tips for effective passwords?

A Use password manager to store passwords, use passphrases if possible. Understand your attack surface, having a password written in a diary kept under lock is far safer than easy passwords. Most attacks happen due to easy passwords or patterns or sequential codes. If worried about nation state actors, having a local only password vault such as KeePass[X/XC] makes more sense than any online solution.

Q Red flags in messages or emails?

A Overly flowery language. For SMSes in India, keep in mind that: Organisations can't send SMS via a 10 digit number. And while you don't share OTP with anyone, also ensure the alphabet code is indicative of the actual services.

Q IoT device safety?

A Routers and home based IoT devices are mostly purchased once, install once and forget they exist. Spending one weekend a month checking and updating household devices can prevent many issues. If you are tech savvy, I would recommend configuring two networks, one for IoT devices, and other for end-user devices like phone, laptop etc.

Q How to stay cyber safe?

A If it's free or dirt cheap, ask yourself how they are making money – mostly it's because you are the product. Avoid piracy and downloading stuff from random sources. If an app is available for a cost, don't try to find a version which is free – mostly those will have security issues or hacks built-in. **■**



Anant Shrivastava